ETHNICS - LATINOS

Tape 9B Phil george

Informant - Archiga 1-26-76

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narrative about la llorona

Recorded in the late afternoon in the living room of the Arechiga home in Gary.

P. I'm about to interview Mrs. Aurora Arechiga in her home.

Au. And she was doing men's work and I didn't think it was fair, or my husband, for her to be working like that, you know. She was getting sick all the time and she has a baby. And that baby was with us all the time and we're having trouble finding somebody to--to stay with her. When I have to go to work, somebody has to stay with her, and, a, it's a mess. But I'm glad he's working.

P. But there's good money in that and it's a..a good job. (Auto body repair)

Au. Soon as they start working, he says, I have to work---I have to wait three weeks for my paycheck. I said it's better than working and waiting all your life you know.

P. Right

Au. Three weeks is nothing.

P. When I was here on Thanksgiving, we were sitting here with...I believe it's your sister-in-law...

Au. My sister-in-law, Vera. Uh huh. (affirmative)

P. Vera, and we were talking about la llorona. And that you had had some experiences---or that---with la llorona. You had heard her or you had seen her.

Au. Well...a...

P. The other thing is, if a...before we go on, I don't care whether this is in Spanish or English. If you're more comfortable in one that the other...

Au. Whatever it comes out, Uh huh. OK.

P. Whatever comes out is fine.

Au. Well, I remember when a--My grandmother--I lived with my grandmother. And my mother. My mother was a widow. She become a widow when she was...a...I think around 21 or 22, something like that. And she was left with three children. Well, two children and she was expecting one. Well, anyways, a, we live a

little while in Texas and then, after there, my grandmother decided to move to Monterrey because she is from there. Her relatives keep on telling her, "Come over here. Probably you live better," you know, "with the children," because she was a widow herself and probably could find a job over here, work closer and everything. Well, when she got there she find out it wasn't so, you know.

Well, anyways, we were--we lived in a little town called...in a, Monterrey. A...What was the name of that place? I was very little. I was about six or so. I guess...Well, anyways, my grandmother remarried with this wonderful man, you know. And, I say wonderful because he was...everything to us, you know. Our father, our grandfather, everything, you know. He was really nice. And a, we lived with them you know. My mother never remarried you know. She stayed single. We were living in...I try to think of the name of the...of that part of town--Well-I'll see if it comes back to my...my mind.

OK, well, we were living on the other side of the river, you know, this, whata you call it, a barranco, you know...

P. Uh huh. (affirmative)

Au. The high ground like that (gestures up with one hand) at the river you know on the other side. A...I remember that--I can--I don't know if...I had dreamed this but it probably is..is what I seen you know. I was too small to--you know, but I--All the time it stick in my mind. Then we live in a house. It was a wooden house. And like, you know, the summertime is too hot over there. Everynight after supper you know, we sit out side. But it is--There were no sidewalks over there. The houses are built right on the edge of the street, you know. The cars--you know, the traffic passed by and everything but was no sidewalks. We just...sit up on the ledte, of the...of the door you know, the doorway. Sit there and talk and most of the time we were saying spooky stories all the time. And I heard it before that everybody says that la llorona appear over there. Nobody's seen it but they heard it, you know. And a...I remember,

you know, we were telling there, hearing all these like Chhhhhh! (moans in a long, drawn out, high pitched tone), like that. You know it kind of give me the chills still, because I can remember real good. I remember my brother and I would--or--when my brother and I sitting there, you know, just hearing the stories and everything, but hearing that a--I'm sure it did happen. A lot of people can question this but I could say that it...I heard it myself

And my grandmother used to tell us "Don't pay attention. That's a soul that...it hasn't rest. Rezen por ella." you know. Este--Ella se murió y su alma no ha descansado por andar buscando a sus hijos. A sus hijos ella los mató. Fué en un rato de celos porque su esposo andaba con otras mujeres. Entonces los mató y los tiró al río. And she's looking for them because when she died, she went to heaven--She tried to go to heaven, you know, the door, and God told her--He says "You're not coming in till you bring the bodys of your children." So, a...her mission in life was for her to go back in life and look for her children. And then she cries all over the rivers. Crying "Aiiiii! Mis hijos!" (again the long,drawn out, high-pitched wail) everywhere and that's... that's why I,--that was my experience when I was little. And I still--The name tries to come back. I can't make it out.

(Laughter from both)

I feel like calling my grandmother. She's in Laredo.

P. In Laredo?

Au. Uh huh. (affirmative) Nuevo Re--Nuevo Repueblo. El Nuevo Repueblo. Ese era el nombre del...

P. Un barrio?

Au. Un barrio, un barrio era Nuevo Repueblo. And there was San Luisito and all these little places which I remember. I remember that we used to cross the river and allí estaba el mercado. El mercado, quien sabe, no me acuerdo. That